

Investigation Report: Suspicious SSH Access and Privileged Account Activity

Findings

The investigation identified a sequence of suspicious activities on the Linux host **MYDFIR-LinuxBOURNE**.

The observed activity included:

- A successful SSH connection from **DESKTOP-RVT13GT / 192.168.2.9** to **MYDFIR-LinuxBOURNE / 192.168.2.6** (My Windows VM was originally named “MYDFIR-JSNBRN”, but for some reason the name got messed up).
- Creation of a new local user account named **supportadmin**.
- Modification of the newly created account's group membership, resulting in administrative privileges through membership in the **sudo** group.
- Creation or modification of the **/home/supportadmin/.ssh/authorized_keys** file, allowing SSH key-based authentication.
- A subsequent SSH connection using the newly created **supportadmin** account.
- Execution of commands with elevated privileges using **sudo**.
- Access to sensitive system account information, including **/etc/passwd** and/or **/etc/shadow**, if confirmed in the logs.
- Deletion of the file **/opt/company-data/financial_report.txt**, as identified by File Integrity Monitoring.

The sequence of events is consistent with suspicious privileged account creation and the establishment of persistent remote access to the Linux host.

Investigation Summary

On **27 August 2026**, suspicious activity was observed on the Linux host **MYDFIR-LinuxBOURNE**. The activity began with a successful SSH connection originating from **DESKTOP-RVT13GT**.

Following the successful authentication, a new local account named **supportadmin** was created. The account was subsequently added to the **sudo** group, granting it administrative privileges on the system.

SSH key-based access was then configured for the newly created account through the creation or modification of the **authorized_keys** file located at:

/home/supportadmin/.ssh/authorized_keys

A subsequent successful SSH authentication involving the **supportadmin** account was observed.

After obtaining privileged access, commands were executed using **sudo**. The investigation also identified the deletion of the file:

/opt/company-data/financial_report.txt

The overall sequence is consistent with an actor establishing a new privileged account and configuring persistent remote access to the Linux host.

At the time of investigation, **no further events were observed**.

Who, What, When, Where, Why, How

Who

The following systems and accounts were involved in the activity:

- Source host: **DESKTOP-RVT13GT**
- Source IP address: **192.168.2.9**
- Destination host: **MYDFIR-LinuxBOURNE**
- Destination IP address: **192.168.2.6**
- Original SSH account: **j-bourne**
- Newly created account: **supportadmin**

The identity and intent of the actor cannot be confirmed based solely on the available logs. However, the activity was performed using the account **j-bourne**, followed by the creation and use of the **supportadmin** account.

What

The investigation identified suspicious account and SSH activity on the Linux host.

The observed actions included:

1. Successful SSH authentication to the Linux system.
2. Creation of a new local user account named **supportadmin**.
3. Addition of **supportadmin** to the **sudo** group.
4. Creation or modification of the account's SSH **authorized_keys** file.
5. Successful SSH access using the newly created account.
6. Execution of commands with elevated privileges.
7. Deletion of **/opt/company-data/financial_report.txt**.

The combination of privileged account creation and SSH key configuration may indicate an attempt to establish persistent administrative access.

When

The suspicious activity occurred on **Aug 27, 2026** between approximately **16:52:46** and **17:10:54**.

All timestamps in this report are presented in **UTC+3**.

The approximate timeline is shown below:

Time	Event
16:52:46	Successful SSH connection to the Ubuntu host
16:54:04	New user account supportadmin created
16:54:48	supportadmin added to the sudo group
16:56:34	.ssh directory and/or authorized_keys file created or modified
17:10:18	SSH authentication using supportadmin observed
17:10:26	Commands executed with elevated privileges
17:10:34	Sensitive system information accessed, if confirmed
17:10:53	/opt/company-data/financial_report.txt deleted

No additional suspicious activity was observed after **17:10:53** based on the available Wazuh telemetry.

Where

The activity occurred across the following hosts:

Source host:

Hostname: DESKTOP-RVT13GT

IP Address: 192.168.2.9

Operating System: Windows 10

Destination host:

Hostname: MYDFIR-LinuxBOURNE

IP Address: 192.168.2.6

Operating System: Ubuntu 24.04.4 LTS

The primary suspicious activity occurred on the Ubuntu host.

Relevant files involved in the investigation included:

/home/supportadmin/.ssh/authorized_keys

/opt/company-data/financial_report.txt

Why

The exact motivation behind the activity cannot be determined from the available telemetry.

However, the sequence of events is consistent with establishing persistent, privileged access to the Linux host.

Creating a new account, assigning it membership in the **sudo** group, and configuring SSH key-based authentication would allow continued remote administrative access without requiring the original account to be used.

The deletion of **financial_report.txt** may indicate an attempt to remove or destroy data. However, based on the available evidence, the intent behind the deletion cannot be confirmed.

How

The activity appears to have occurred through the following sequence:

1. An existing user account successfully authenticated to the Ubuntu host over SSH.
2. The authenticated account used elevated privileges to create a new local user named **supportadmin**.
3. The new account was added to the **sudo** group.
4. SSH key-based authentication was configured by creating or modifying:

/home/supportadmin/.ssh/authorized_keys

5. The **supportadmin** account was subsequently used to establish an SSH connection to the host.
6. Administrative commands were executed using **sudo**.
7. A monitored file, **/opt/company-data/financial_report.txt**, was deleted.

This sequence allowed the newly created account to obtain privileged access and potentially maintain persistent remote access to the system.

Recommendations

1. Investigate the supportadmin account.

Determine whether the account was authorised. If it is not required, disable or remove it.

2. Review privileged group membership.

Audit all accounts belonging to the sudo group and verify that administrative privileges are assigned according to the principle of least privilege.

3. Review SSH authorised keys.

Inspect authorized_keys files for all users and remove unknown or unauthorised public keys.

4. Restrict SSH access.

Limit SSH access to authorised users and hosts. Where possible, use network restrictions, allowlists, and firewall rules.

5. Implement stronger SSH monitoring.

Generate alerts for:

- New user creation.
- Addition of users to privileged groups.
- Creation or modification of SSH authorized_keys files.
- Successful SSH logins from newly created accounts.
- Unusual privileged command execution.

6. Monitor sensitive file activity.

Continue using Wazuh File Integrity Monitoring for important directories and configure appropriate alerting for file deletion and modification events.

7. Review the originating host.

Investigate **DESKTOP-RVT13GT** to determine whether the SSH activity was authorized and whether the originating account or host may have been compromised.

8. Preserve relevant logs.

Retain authentication, system, and Wazuh alert data associated with the incident to support further investigation.

9. Establish an account creation approval process.

New privileged accounts should require authorization and should be documented to make unauthorized account creation easier to identify.

Conclusion

The investigation identified a sequence of suspicious activities involving SSH access, creation of a new privileged account, modification of SSH authentication configuration, and deletion of a monitored file.

The account **supportadmin** was created and granted administrative privileges through membership in the **sudo** group. SSH key-based authentication was subsequently configured, followed by remote access using the newly created account.

While the available telemetry does not conclusively establish malicious intent, the observed sequence is consistent with the establishment of persistent privileged access and should be investigated as potentially unauthorized activity.

The recommended actions include validating the legitimacy of the involved accounts and SSH keys, reviewing privileged access, restricting SSH access, and improving monitoring for account and authentication-related activity.